

Dating on a budget

When I embarked on the Pocket Money Savings Plan, I hadn't banked on meeting boys.

Dating costs a fortune: drinks on a Friday night, dinner on Saturday and, if that last date went well, brunch on Sunday. What's more, as I discovered, revealing that your parents are the gatekeepers of your finances in your 30s is as awkward as the first kiss.

I didn't tell the man I dated shortly after I enacted the plan about my restricted cash flow. Looming over the thrill of flirty texts and making plans was the savings spectre. I was ashamed to admit to him I had such weak financial self-control that I was yet to trust myself with access to all of my salary. My secret niggled at me, and there were nights out in his company when I worried whether I had enough in my account to pay for another round of drinks. The nerves of wondering 'Does he like me?' had nothing on the heart-racing moments of tapping my debit card at the bar, in front of him, and sweating to see if it would beep and read, 'Declined'.

I frequently excused myself on our rendezvous to go to the bathroom, not to touch up my lipstick and ruffle my hair, but to fossick privately in my purse to count the slim wad of notes and stray coins, calculating the likely duration of the date versus my remaining dollars. He must have thought me vain instead of mingy. Was it too soon to suggest leaving the bar and retiring to my apartment for a coffee or a glass of Aldi wine? In dating land, the invitation to your place means something else entirely, though going home is a lot cheaper than staying out. Were we ready to sleep over, if that's how he interpreted the invitation? Not yet, but I was running out of money, and it was either 'Back to mine?' or calling it a night, and sending a signal that I was just not that interested. The internal war of a singleton saver.

I searched online for budget dating ideas. A women's magazine suggested a tandem bike ride, applying face masks together at home, riding a ferry and going antiquing. I do not own a bike, I don't want to date a man who is more into beauty products than I am, the nearest ferry I could find